

CORE FORMULA

Ask -> Tell -> Ask -> Ask: "What's your sense of this so far?" -> Tell: the one point that matters, concisely. -> Ask: "How does that land?" -> Field rule: use the structure to organise your thinking, then speak like a person.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Ask one real question about where they are, tell one clear point, then ask what they make of it.

BEST FOR

- Teaching or explaining something new
- Giving feedback
- Clinical or medical explanations
- Coaching conversations
- Sharing complex information without overwhelming
- Making a concise, memorable contribution in a meeting

PHRASE BANK

Opening asks · Find their starting point

- "What's your sense of this so far?"
- "Where are you with this already?"
- "What do you already know about it?"
- "What's your read on it?"
- "Before I jump in - what's your starting point?"
- "How much of the background have you got?"
- "What's your gut feeling on it?"
- "What have you tried so far?"

Warm framing · Before you tell

- "I want to make sure this is actually useful to you."
- "Tell me where you're up to and I'll fill the gaps."
- "I'd rather meet you where you are than talk over your head."
- "There's no wrong answer here - I just want your starting point."
- "Whatever you already know, we can build from there."
- "I'll keep this short, and you tell me if it helps."
- "Let me check I'm being useful and not just talking."

Meetings, email and status · Work contexts

- "Quick context check: what's already landed with everyone?"
- "Here's the one thing that matters, then I'll take questions."
- "The headline is X; the detail is only there if you want it."
- "I'll give you the short version - say if you need more."
- "Where's the group on this before I share the update?"
- "I've put the main point first so you can scan it."
- "That's the key point. What would make it clearer for the decision?"

The point and the closing ask · Tell then check

- "Here's the key point, in one line."

- "The main thing is X; the rest is only support."
- "That's the core of it. How does that land?"
- "What do you make of that?"
- "Does that match what you were expecting?"
- "What's your reaction to that?"
- "What questions does that raise for you?"
- "What would you do with that?"

When the structure misses · Reset and simplify

- "I made that too structured - let me say it more simply."
- "That may not be the useful frame. Let me back up."
- "I don't want the structure to override the actual issue."
- "What part of that was useful, and what should we drop?"
- "Let me try that again in plain words."
- "I think I lectured a bit there. What's the real question?"
- "Forget the framework - what do you actually need from me?"

Feedback and sensitive moments · Handle with care

- "Can I share what I'm seeing, and then hear your take?"
- "Before I give feedback - what's your own read on how it went?"
- "Here's the one thing I'd change. How does that sit with you?"
- "What have you been told so far?"
- "I'll tell you the main point plainly, then we can sit with it."
- "What matters most to you to understand right now?"
- "Is this a good moment for the detail, or do you need a minute?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Using Ask-Tell-Ask as a visible script, naming each step and sounding rehearsed.
Better: Using Ask-Tell-Ask silently to organise a concise response.
Best: Using it flexibly, then checking whether the listener is clearer, more heard, or better able to respond.
2. Weak: Telling everything you know in case some of it turns out to be useful.
Better: Telling the one key point and stopping.
Best: Telling the one point, then genuinely asking what they make of it.
3. Weak: Asking "Make sense?" as a full stop.
Better: Asking an open question at the end.
Best: Asking, then letting their answer change your next sentence.

DECISION TREE

If The listener needs speed

Use the shortest version - one-line ask, one-line tell, one-line ask.
"Quick sense-check: does this land?"

If The listener needs support

Validate first and delay the framework until the emotion settles.
"That sounds hard. We can get to the detail when you're ready."

If The listener needs a story or example

Switch to an example-oriented neighbour such as STAR or CARL.
"Let me give you a concrete example instead."

If The listener needs action

End with one clean next step rather than an open reflection.
"So the next step is X - does that work?"

If The listener already understands

Drop the Tell entirely; confirm and move on.
"Sounds like you've got it - anything I can add?"

SCENARIOS

Work meeting

Check what's already landed, give one point, invite reaction - keeps your contribution concise and memorable. —
"Where's everyone on this? The key point is the deadline moved. What does that change for you?"

Email or written update

Put the main point first, keep the tell to short paragraphs or bullets, end with an open question. — "Quick check on where you're up to. Here's the one change. What would you want to know next?"

Giving feedback

Ask what kind of feedback would help before you structure anything. — "What's your own read on how it went? Here's the one thing I'd change. How does that sit?"

Difficult conversation

Use one sentence per step and pause between them; don't stack. — "What's your sense of where we are? Here's what I'm worried about. What do you make of it?"

Explaining something technical

Find their starting point so you don't over- or under-explain. — "How much of this have you used before? The bit that trips people up is X. Want to try it?"

Clinical or high-stakes information

Ask what they already understand, tell the main point plainly, ask what it raises - with extra care. — "What have you been told so far? The main thing is X. What questions does that bring up?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Token collaboration where the questions are for show, not genuine input
- Urgent commands, where a single direct instruction is what's needed
- When the person has already declined your advice
- When physical safety or an emergency response takes priority
- Raw emotional moments where listening, validation or repair should come first
- When the person clearly already understands - telling would only pad the moment

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the urge

Notice three moments today when you're about to explain something. Just catch the urge to tell before you ask - no need to change anything yet.

Day 2 — Write one

Take a real situation and write a 60-second response using Ask -> Tell -> Ask. Mark the three parts so you can see them.

Day 3 — Cut it

Cut that response by a third without losing the core point. The Tell should end up as one clear line.

Day 4 — Two voices

Say it aloud twice - once as a visible structure, once as plain speech. Keep the plain version and drop any step labels.

Day 5 — Open the ask

Rewrite your closing question so it can't be answered with just "yes". Use it once in a real conversation and watch what it opens.

Day 6 — Recover on purpose

In a live conversation, notice if the structure misses and practise one recovery line to reset without defending the framework.

Day 7 — Full run

Use the whole move once with someone real: ask their starting point, tell one point, ask what they make of it - and let their answer change what you say next.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I use Ask-Tell-Ask to serve the listener, or to sound polished?
- Did I find out what they already knew before I told them?
- Was the core point clear and short?
- Did the final ask actually invite a response?
- Did I adapt when they needed something else?
- Did I preserve their autonomy and dignity?